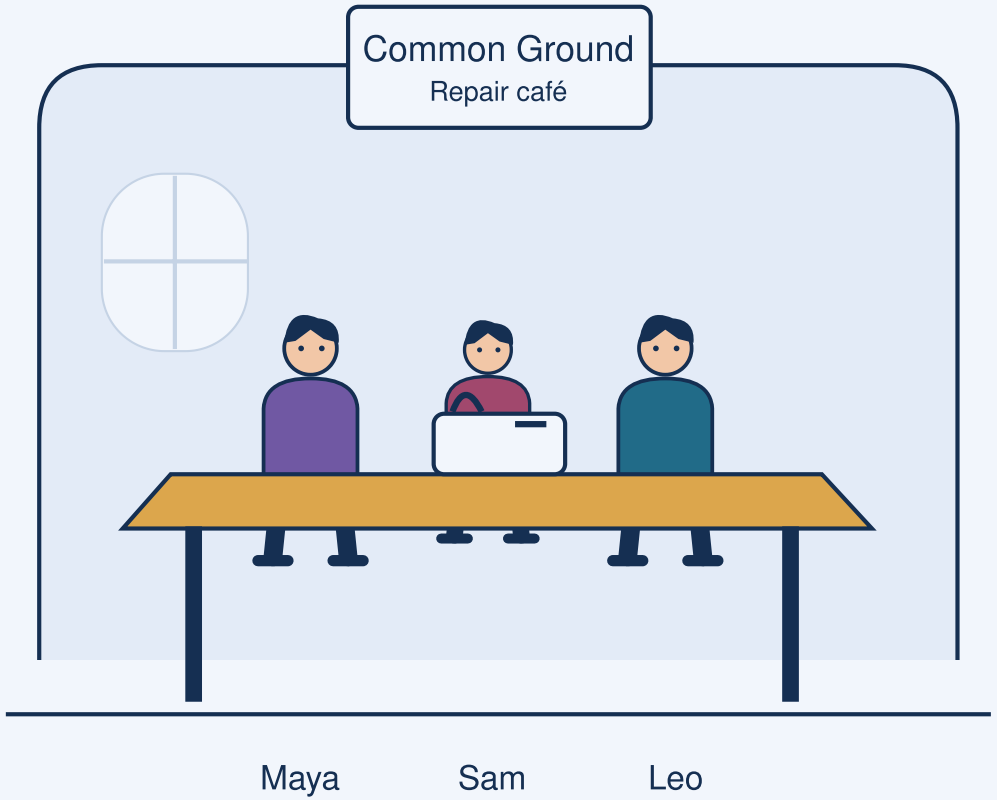
A brighter poster. More visitors. A cause?

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

Which statement fits Leo’s evidence?

A The poster caused the increase.

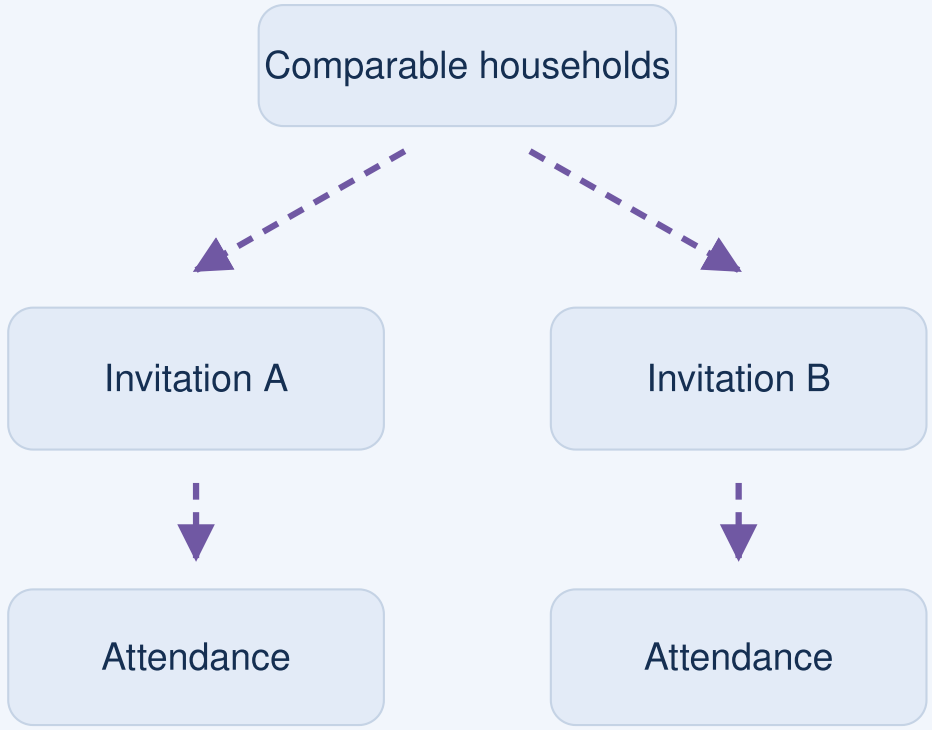
B The poster had no effect.

C Attendance rose; several causes remain possible.

Suggested answer: C. This preserves the observation without claiming to isolate a cause.

Comparison makes a claim testable.

- Correlation: things vary together.
- Confounding: another factor may explain the pattern.
- Random assignment: allocate conditions by chance.

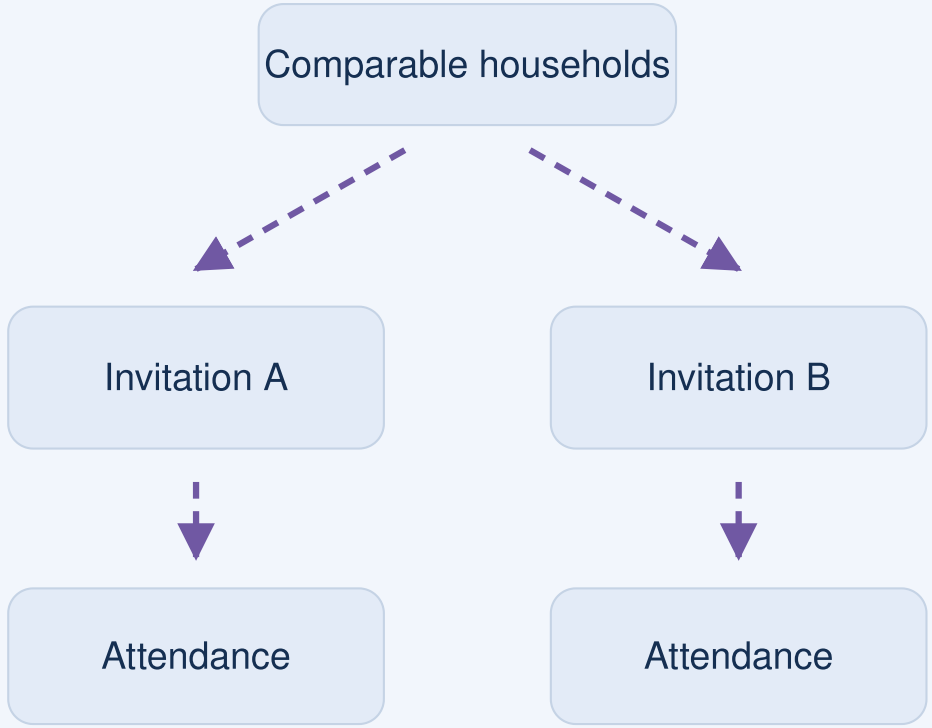


Allocate by chance. Compare like with like.

Random assignment supports a fairer comparison.

Ask how much—and how uncertain.

- Define the outcome before looking.
- Report the size of the difference.
- Examine uncertainty, missing data, and the sample.

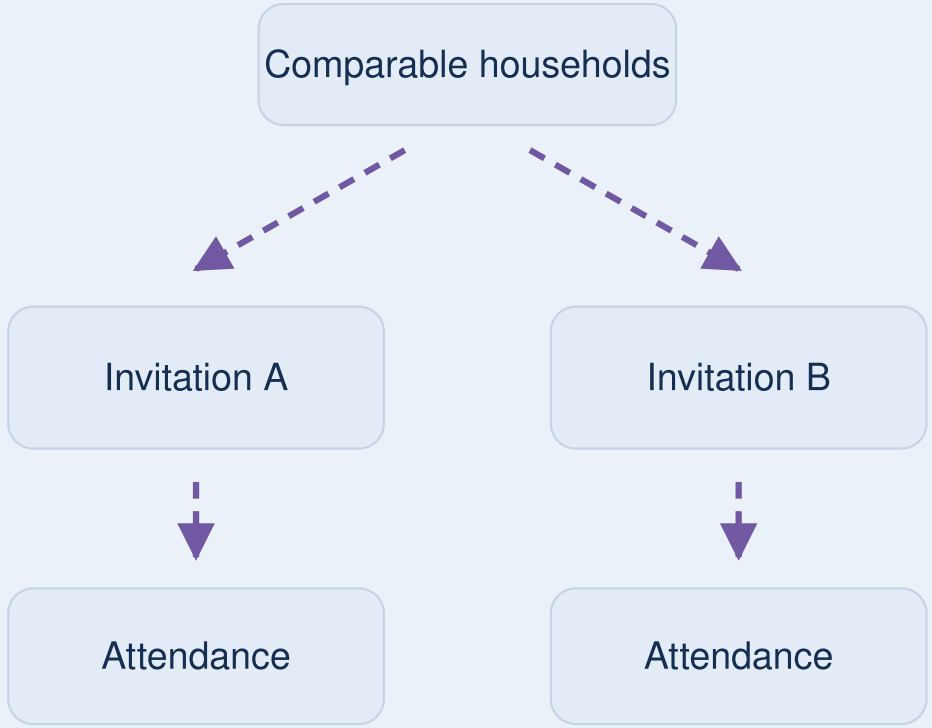


Allocate by chance. Compare like with like.

Random assignment supports a fairer comparison.

What can we really conclude?

Replication examines how dependable a finding is across repeated tests. Preregistration records planned methods and analyses before results are known, reducing some opportunities for selective reporting. It cannot rescue a poor design. Larger samples improve precision; transparent materials and independent tests help others evaluate the claim. A memorable study is a starting point, not a final verdict.



Allocate by chance. Compare like with like.

Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Which invitation comparison is strongest?

A Design A in winter; design B in summer.

B Randomize designs for one event; define attendance in advance.

C Design A for existing fans; design B for newcomers.

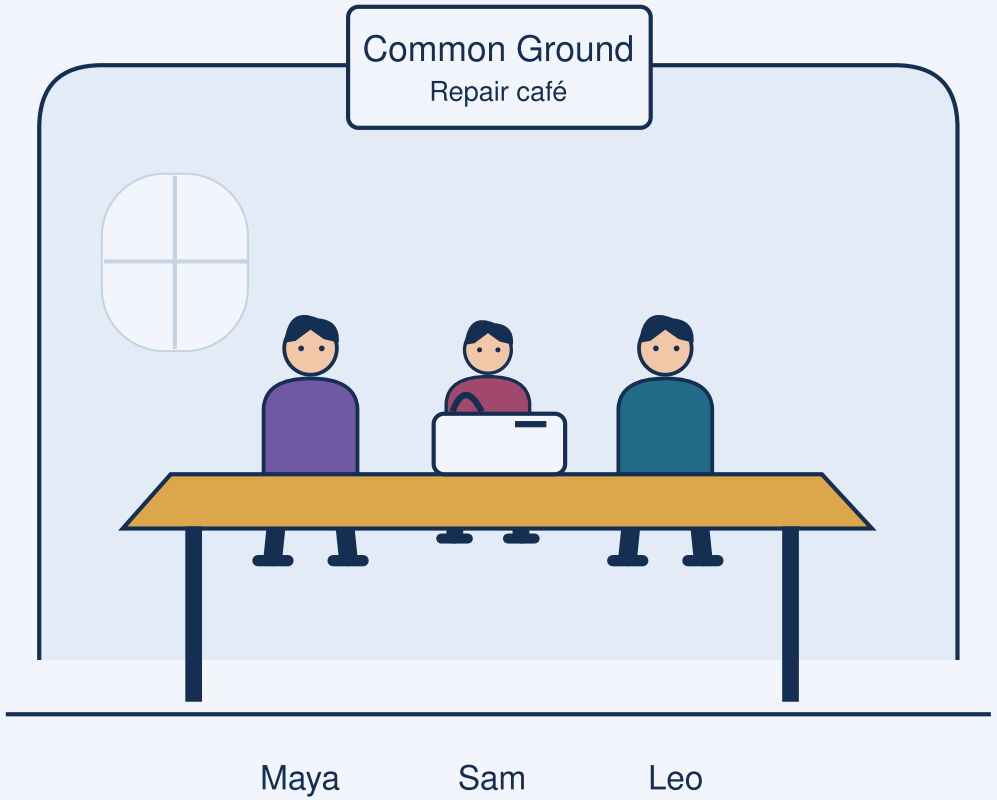
Suggested answer: B. This improves comparability. Also check whether households share invitations.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> How does assignment differ from sampling?

> Why is before-and-after evidence insufficient?

1. Assignment allocates conditions; sampling selects people.
2. Other conditions can change over time and produce the same pattern.

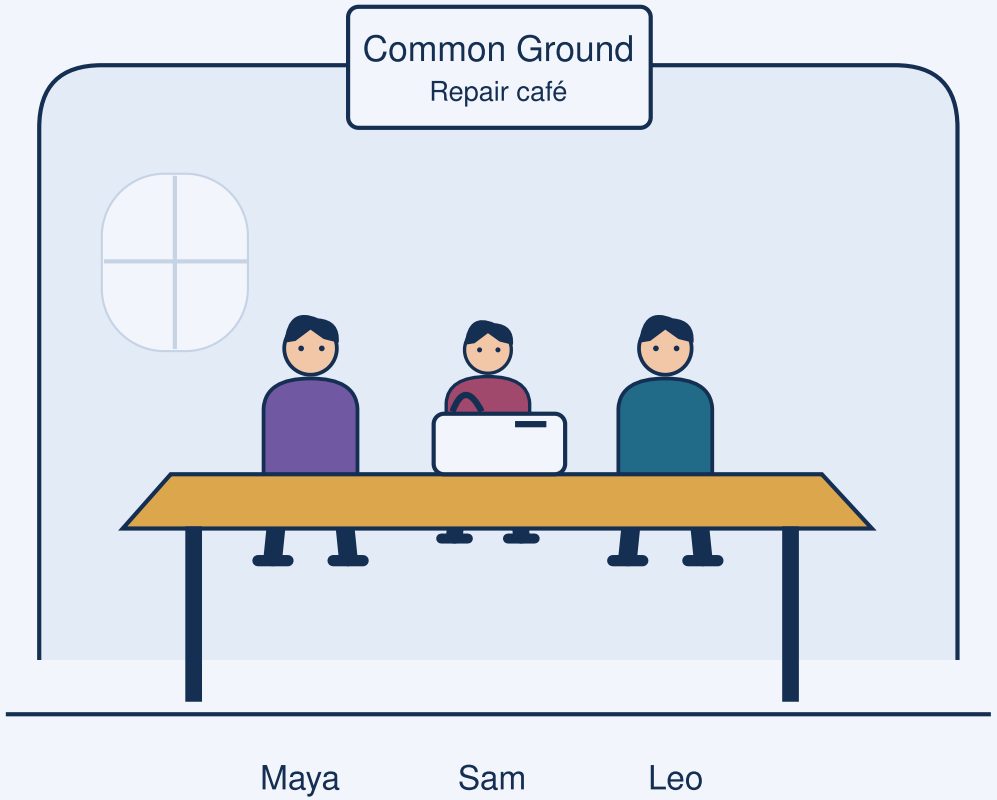


Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Find an everyday causal claim. Name its outcome, one competing explanation, and a feasible comparison. State whose behavior the result would represent.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.